
VISUAL STORYTELLING

Explaining visually
is a form of writing

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Summary

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- A photograph of a banana peel lying on a light gray surface. The peel is yellow with some brown spots, indicating it is ripe. It is curved and broken into two main pieces, with the stem end still attached to one of them. The lighting is soft, creating a slight shadow beneath the peel.
1. Explanatory vs. exploratory
 2. Visualization as technical mediation
 3. Visualization is a form of writing

Explanatory vs. exploratory

FOOD CHAIN

The food chain is a continuous process. At any moment something is being eaten, dies, breaks down, and is being eaten again. It can never have less than three stages.

Here's how it can work:

Predators:

- Dolphins
- Bats
- Penguins
- Frogs

Apex predators:

- Panthers
- Bears
- Pythons
- Black mambas

An apex predator is at the top of the food chain with no predator of its own.

DIFFERENT FOOD CHAINS

Big to small

Small to big

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WHALE-SIZE LUNCH

The largest animal on Earth has a food chain with only three links. (No other mammal on the planet is two steps above microscopic in the food chain.)

A blue whale may consume up to 6.3–7.3 metric tons/6.9–8 tons of food per day during the summer feeding season.

That's 3,628 kilograms/8,000 pounds of krill per day!

For the other eight months of the year, it apparently doesn't eat anything at all, living off stored fat.

Jan Feb Mar Apr May Jun Jul Aug Sep Oct Nov Dec

Eats Does not eat

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PRODUCTION LINE

A veritable factory, the average human body contains and produces all kinds of substances! See what it has up its sleeve...

BIG BEARD
If the average man never shaved his beard, it would grow up to 4 metres/13 feet long.

BLOW OUT
With every breath, it lets out about 40,000 droplets to 100 miles/160 kilometres per hour.

FULL TANK
It contains enough water to fill a 38 litre/8 gallon tank.

GET WIND
It produces over 0.47 litres/0.8 pints of gas every day.

MUCUS

FAT

SALT

SUPER CELL

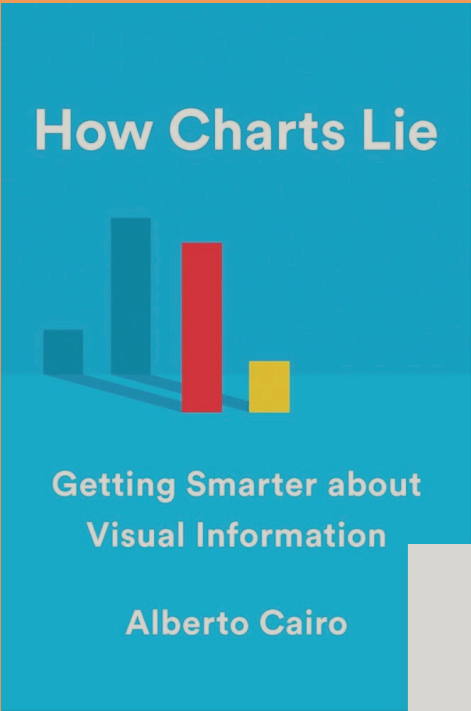
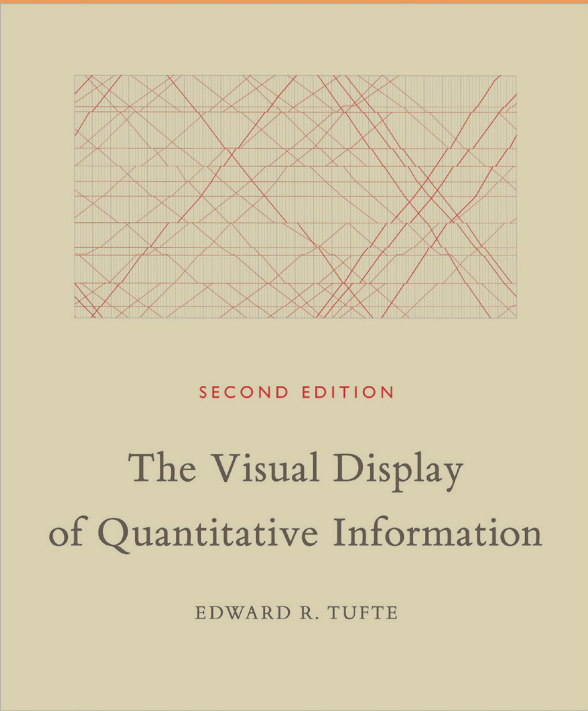
BILE

78

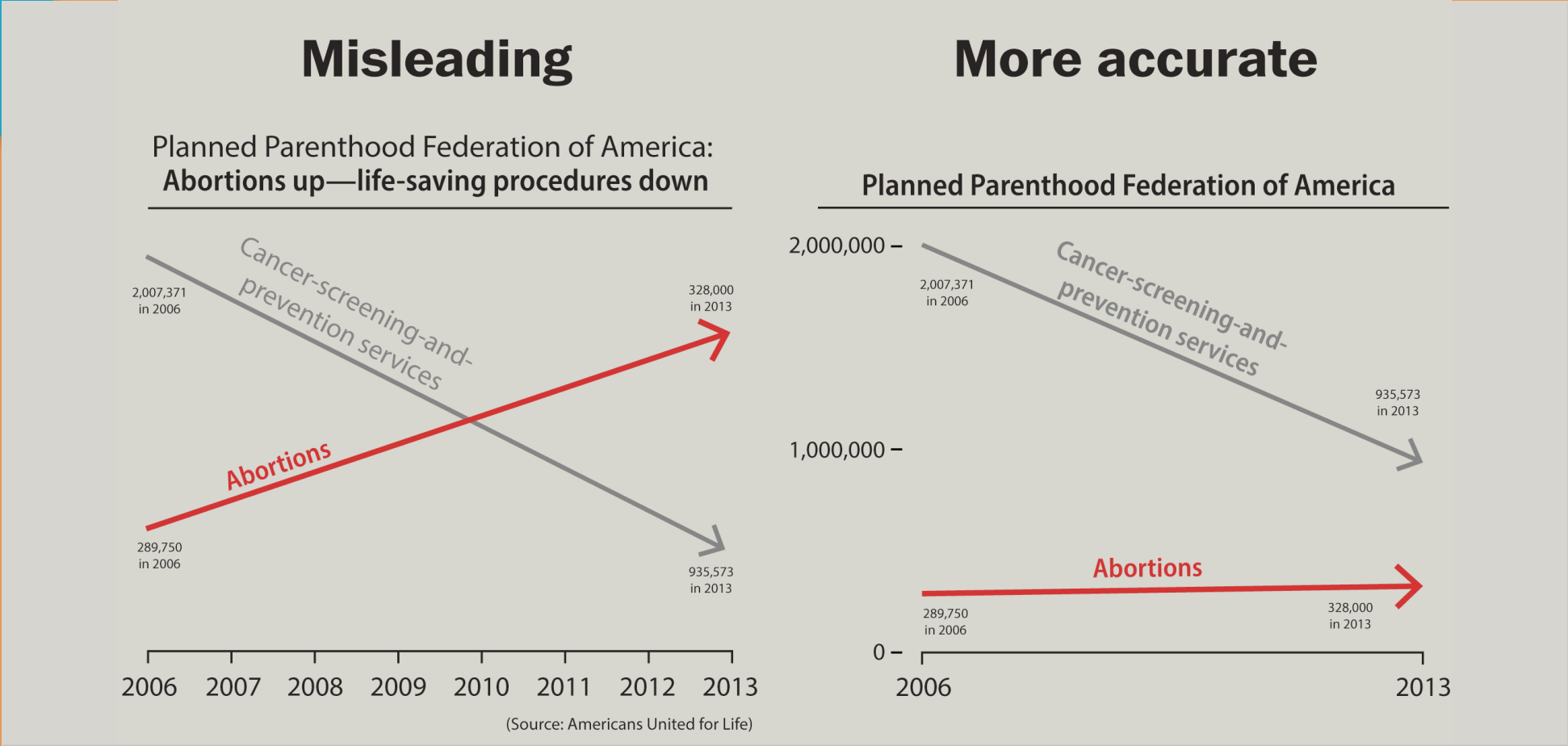
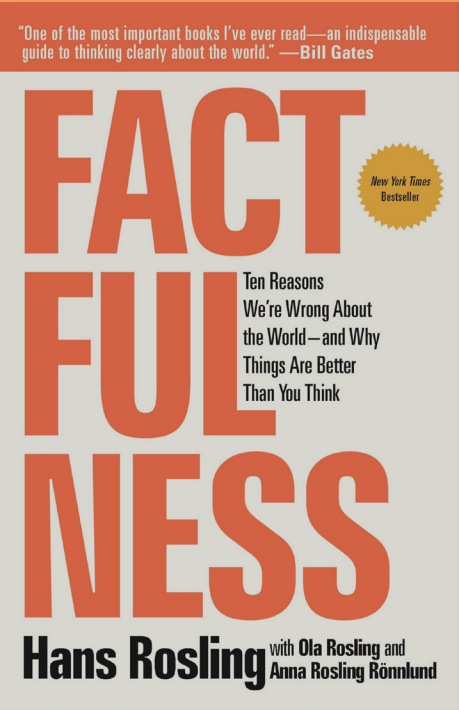
Illustrations by Nicholas Blechman

Explanatory visualization aims to convey a message as efficiently as possible.

Visualization, as technical mediation, is non-neutral



When we produce a visualization, we need to be able to explain what is going on for each mediation involved.



Data visualization is a form of writing

Many rules are the same:

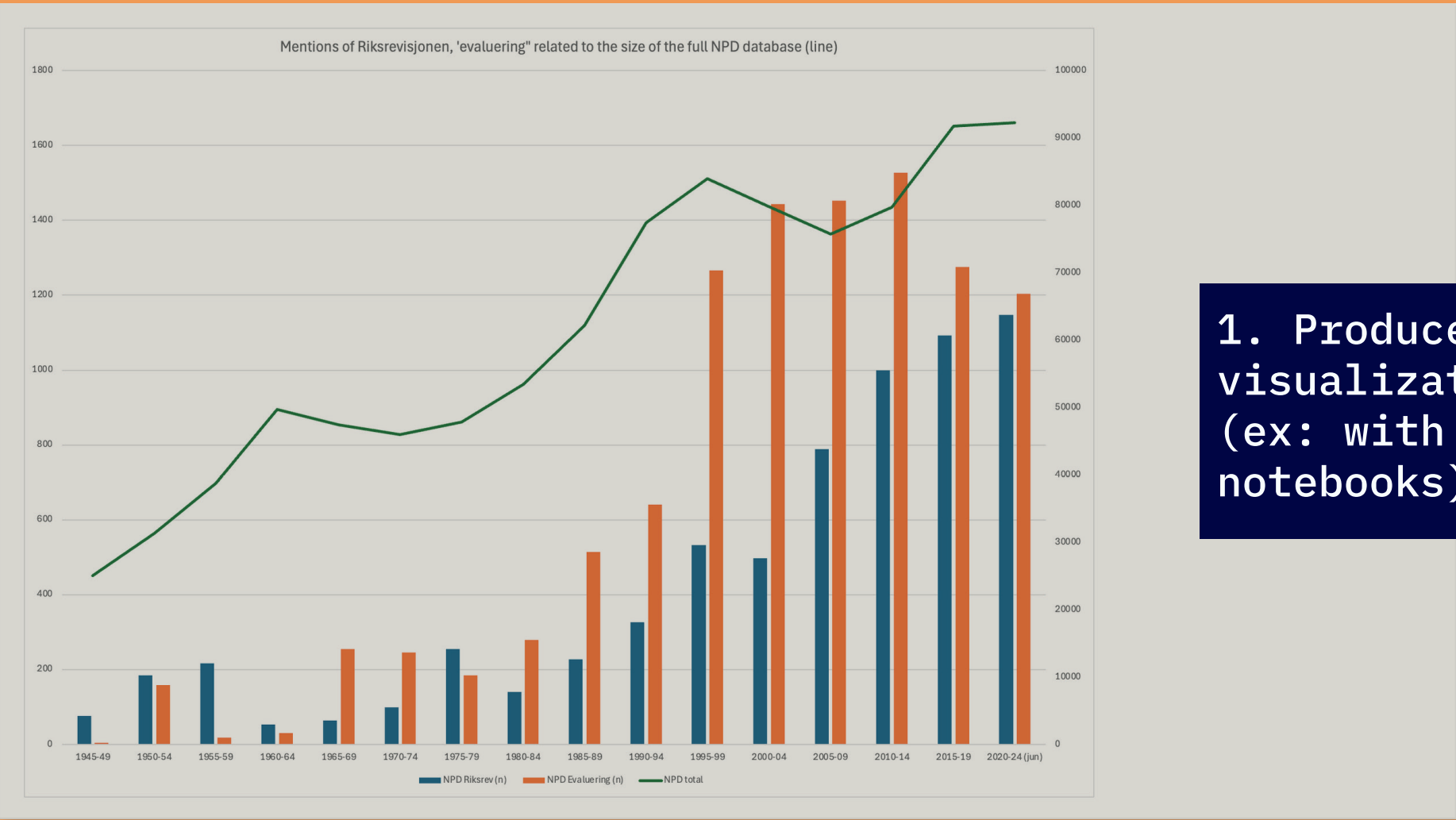
- Never use a complex visualization when a simple one will do.
- First visualize for yourself, then worry about the audience.
- Be like a butcher (you can always cut).
- Every writer needs a reader.
- Truth is a paradox—opposing ideas form the tension of a great story.
- You can do whatever you want as long as you make it work.
- Show, don't tell.

Data visualization is a form of writing

Argumenting that way entails those core steps:

1. Produce the data visualization itself
2. Provide the necessary context
3. Point to the relevant visual pattern
(you may additionally state what the pattern is)
4. Interpret what the pattern means
5. Justify how it is meaningful and provide the larger context in accompanying text

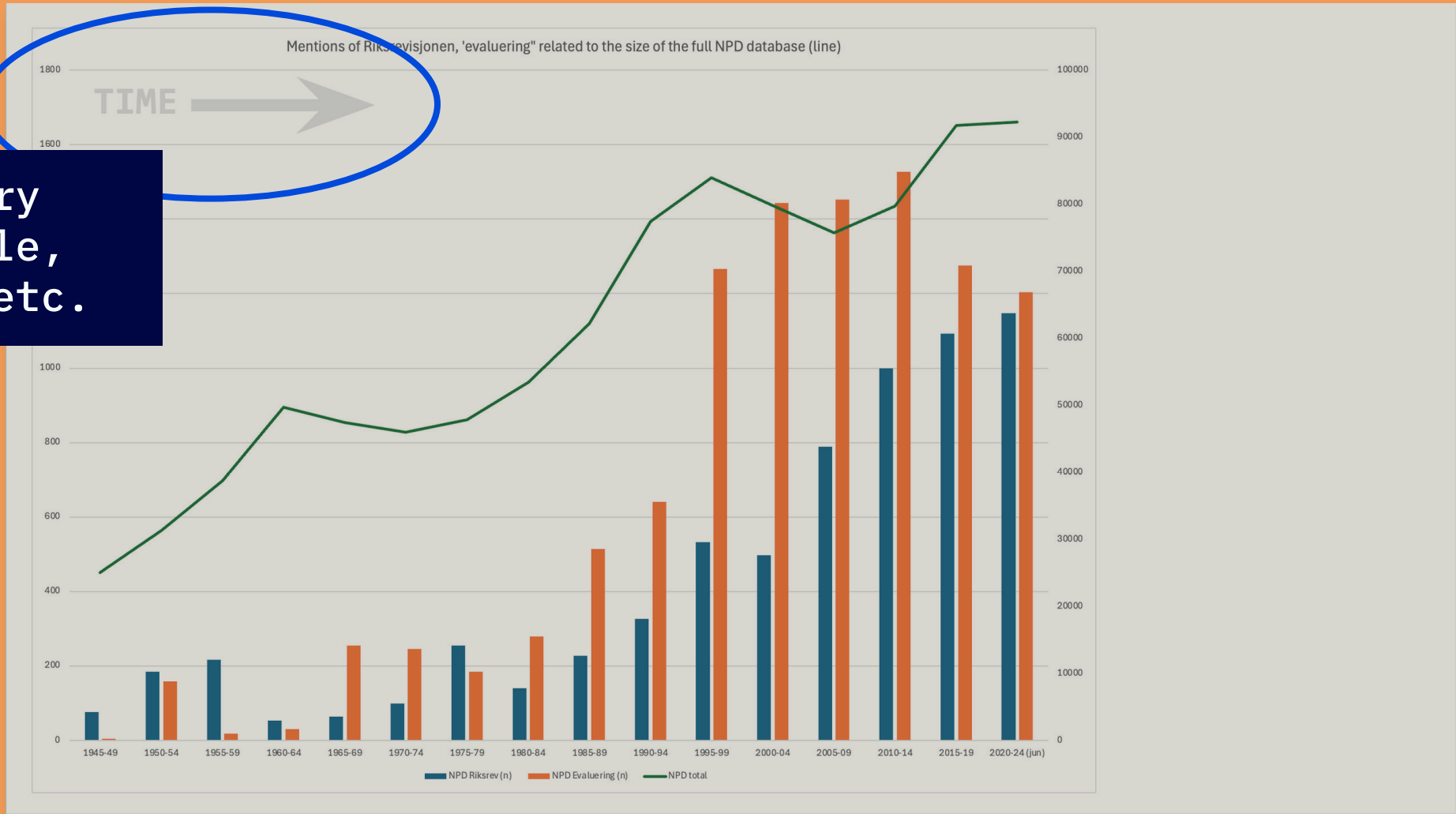
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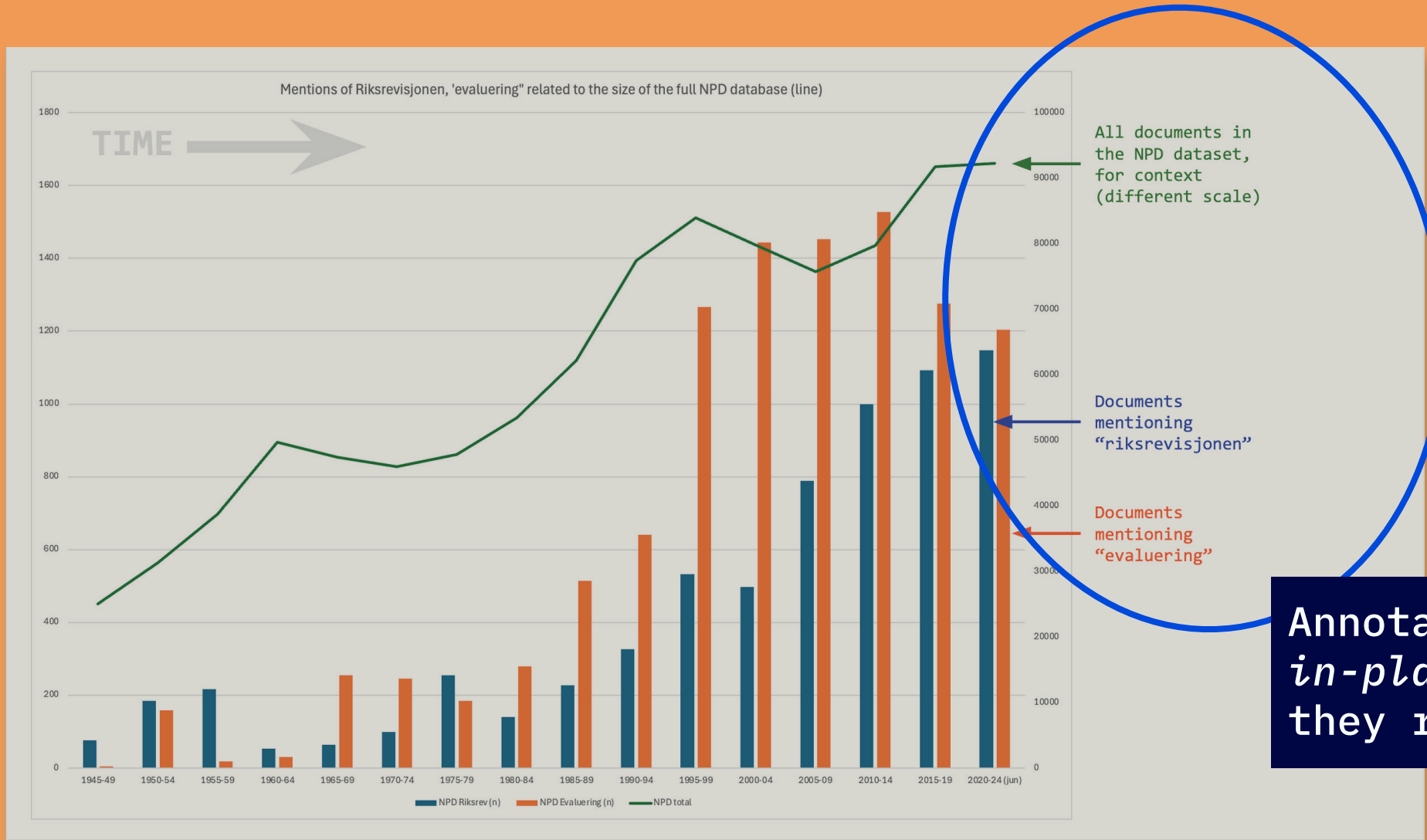
1. Produce the visualization (ex: with the notebooks)

Data visualization is a form of writing

2. Add the necessary context: add a title, clarify the axes, etc.



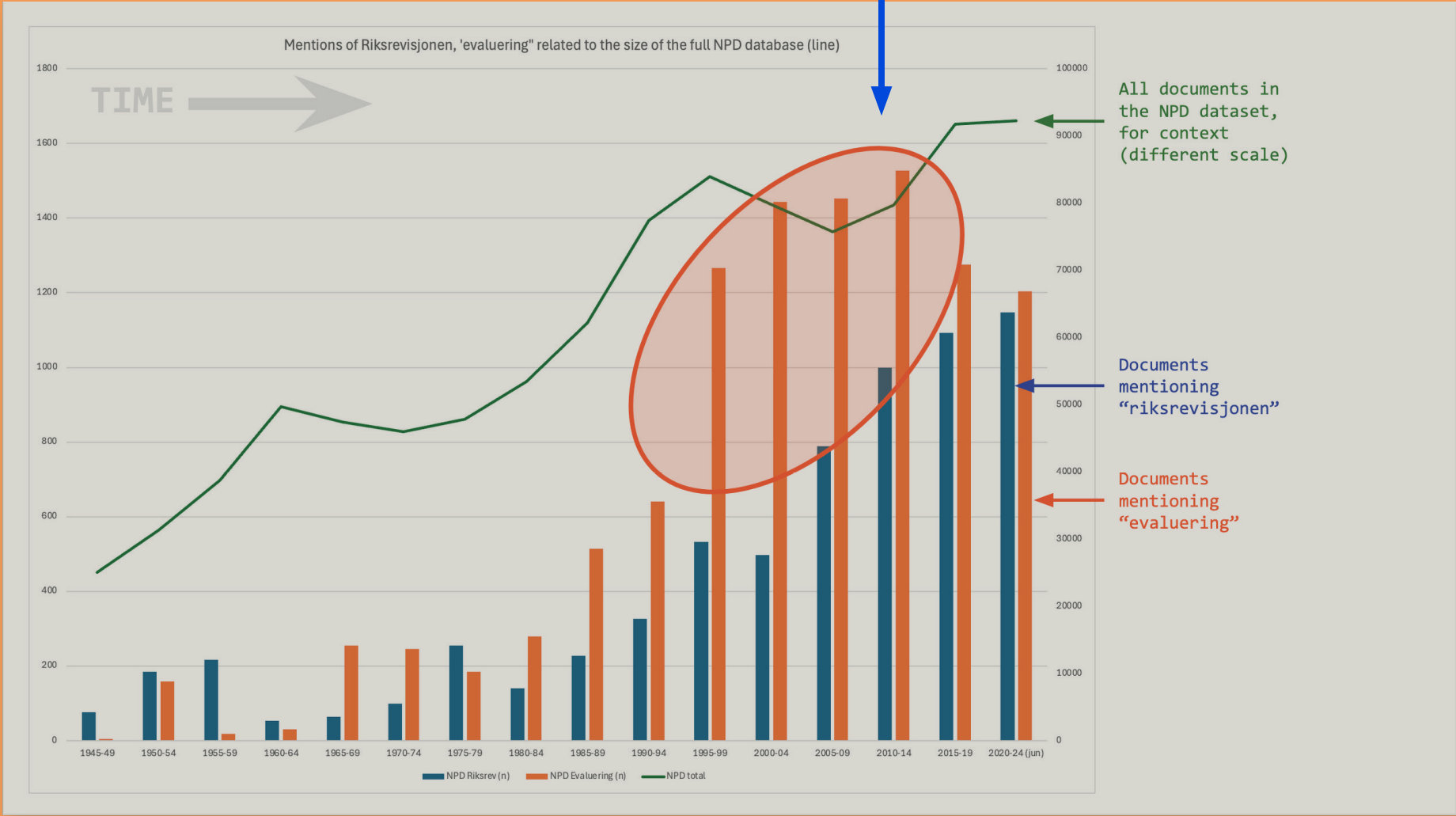
Data visualization is a form of writing



Annotations should be *in-place*: close to what they refer to.

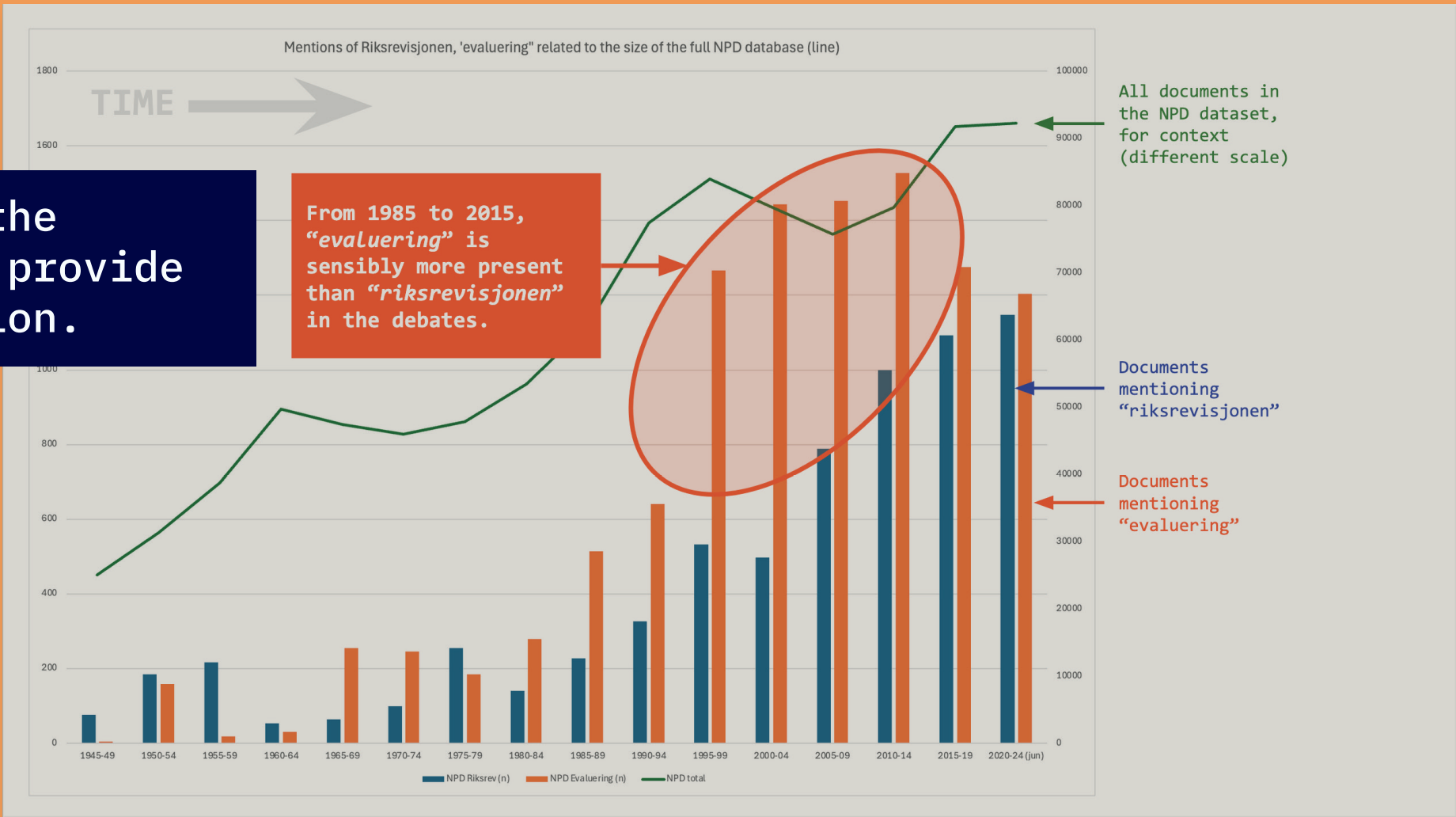
Data visualization is a form of writing

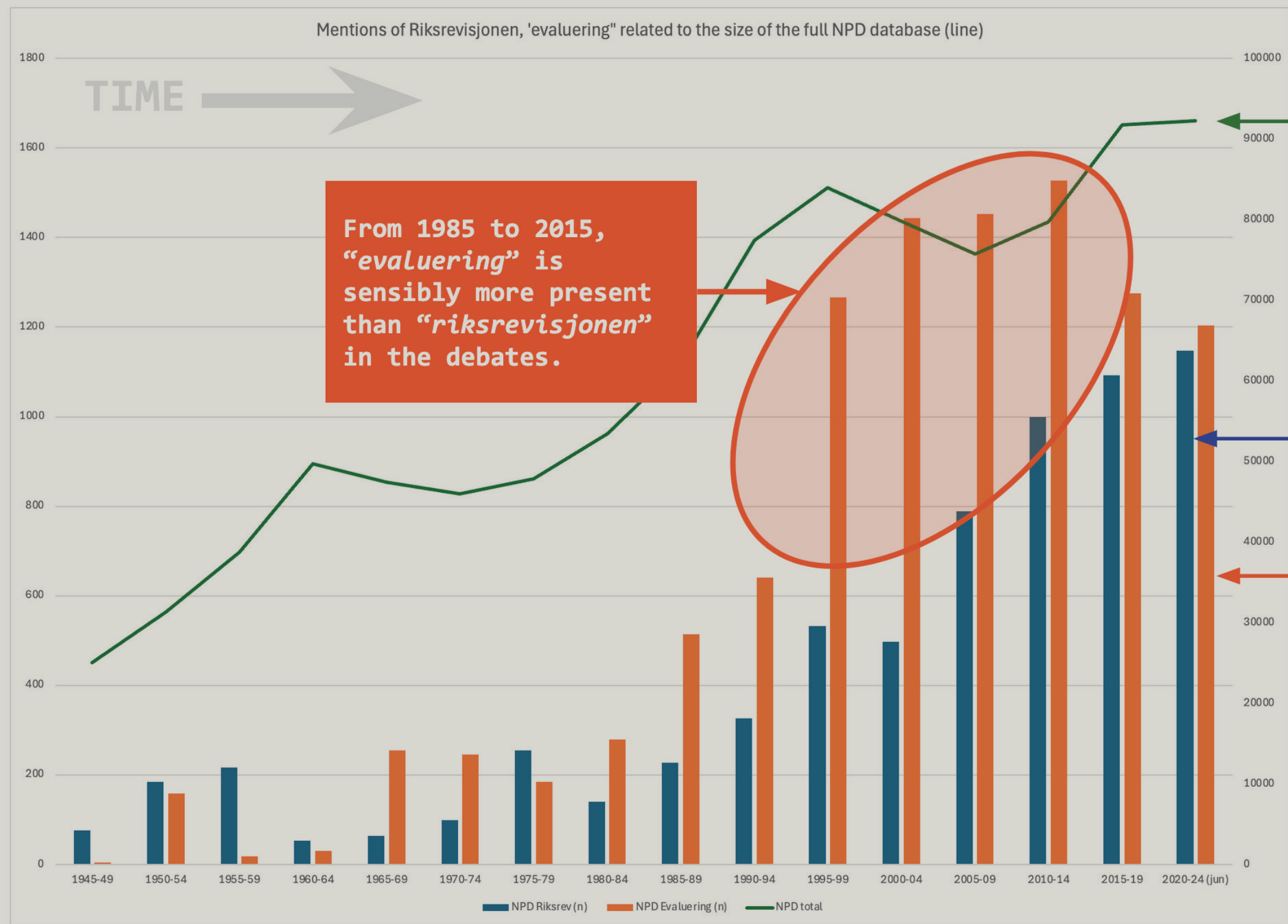
3. Highlight the visual pattern supporting your argument!



Data visualization is a form of writing

4. State what the pattern means: provide an interpretation.





All documents in the NPD dataset, for context (different scale)

Documents mentioning "riksrevisjonen"

Documents mentioning "evaluating"

5. Explain with more details in the accompanying text.



How to annotate with a simple drawing tool

Demo

A banana peel is shown on a solid pink background. The peel is yellow with some brown spots, indicating it is ripe. It is curved and has a small stem at the top. The peel is positioned on the left side of the image, with the text and logo to its right.

THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION

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